

Tough Mudder 5K Training Plan

Target: Twin Cities Tough Mudder 5K, Hugo MN (Wild Wings of Oneka), June 26, 2027

Start date: August 3, 2026. That's 47 weeks. Plenty of runway.

3 days per week. Every session works in a hotel room. Gym and outdoor versions noted where they help.

What the race actually demands

The 5K is 3.1 miles with 12+ obstacles. The running is the easy part. What ends people's day:

1. **Grip strength.** Monkey bar traverses, rope-assisted wall climbs, hanging obstacles. Grip fails before arms do.
2. **Pulling strength.** Hauling yourself over walls and up inclines.
3. **Terrain, not distance.** The Hugo course runs off-trail through pine forest, wetland, and bog. Thick suction mud, uneven glacial ground. Your ankles and hips do more work than your lungs.
4. **Getting up off the ground repeatedly.** Crawls, mud pits, water trenches. Squat-to-stand under fatigue.

The plan weights grip and pulling heavier than a normal 5K plan would.

Weekly structure (same all 47 weeks)

Day	Focus	Where
Day 1	Run	Outside, treadmill, or hotel stairwell
Day 2	Strength	Hotel room, straps, or gym
Day 3	Circuit	Hotel room, zero equipment

Space them out. Don't stack all three back to back if you can help it.

PHASE 1: Base

Weeks 1-10 (Aug 3 - Oct 11, 2026) Goal: run 30 minutes continuously. Build tendon and joint tolerance. No heroics.

Day 1: Run progression

Week	Session
1	1 min run / 2 min walk x 8
2	1.5 / 2 x 7
3	2 / 2 x 7
4	3 / 2 x 6
5	4 / 2 x 5
6	5 / 2 x 4, then 5 min walk
7	8 / 2 x 3
8	12 / 2 x 2, then 6 min run
9	20 min continuous, walk 5, 8 min continuous
10	30 min continuous

5 min brisk walk to warm up, 5 min to cool down, every time. Pace: you should be able to talk in full sentences. If you can't, slow down.

Hotel version: treadmill at the same intervals. No treadmill? Stairwell. Walk up, walk down, same work/rest timing.

Day 2: Strength (hotel room, no equipment)

3 rounds, 60 sec rest between rounds:

- Bodyweight squat x 15
- Push-up x 8-12 (hands on desk or bed edge if floor push-ups aren't there yet)
- Reverse lunge x 10 each leg

- Glute bridge x 15
- Bent-over row with backpack loaded with books x 12
- Plank 30 sec
- Dead bug x 10 each side

Add 1 rep per exercise every week. When you hit 20 reps, add a fourth round and reset to 15.

Day 3: Circuit

5 rounds. 40 sec work, 20 sec rest, 60 sec between rounds:

1. Bear crawl (in place if the room is small: hands and toes, knees hovering, alternate shoulder taps)
2. Squat to stand, fast
3. Push-up to shoulder tap
4. Mountain climbers
5. Step-back burpee (no jump)

Phase 1 daily habit

Dead hang. Once a day, wherever you can find a bar. Hotel gym, playground, doorway bar at home. Hang until you can't. Log the seconds. That's it. Get to 60 seconds by the end of Phase 1.

PHASE 2: Strength Build

Weeks 11-24 (Oct 12, 2026 - Jan 17, 2027) Minnesota winter. This is treadmill and hotel season. Lean into strength while running maintains.

Day 1: Run

- Weeks 11-16: 30-35 min easy, once a week add 5 min of 4% treadmill incline walking in the middle
- Weeks 17-24: alternate weeks
 - **Week A:** 35 min easy continuous

- **Week B:** Incline intervals. 3 min at 6-8% incline (walk or slow jog) / 3 min flat easy, x 6

Incline work matters more than speed here. The Hugo course is off-trail slog, not a road race.

Day 2: Strength (this is the phase that wins the race)

4 rounds:

- **Rows** x 10. Suspension straps or dumbbell rows. Go heavy enough that 10 is hard.
- **Split squat** x 10 each leg. Hold dumbbells or a loaded backpack.
- **Push-up** x 12, or dumbbell floor press
- **Farmer carry** 40 sec. Heaviest dumbbells in the hotel gym, one in each hand, walk. No gym? Loaded suitcase in each hand up and down the hallway.
- **Hollow hold** 30 sec
- **Dead hang** to failure

Day 3: Circuit

6 rounds, 40 on / 20 off:

1. Bear crawl forward and back
2. Jump squat
3. Push-up
4. Reverse lunge, alternating
5. Low crawl (belly on floor, army crawl, 10 ft and back)
6. Burpee

Phase 2 grip work (do this after every session)

- **Dead hang:** build 60 sec to 90 sec
 - **Towel hang:** drape a hotel towel over the bar, grip the towel ends. Brutal, and the closest thing to a wet muddy rope you can train indoors. Start at 10 sec.
 - **Suitcase hold:** heaviest dumbbell, one hand, hold 30 sec each side
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PHASE 3: Race Specific

Weeks 25-38 (Jan 18 - Apr 25, 2027) Goal: 4 miles comfortably, plus obstacle-specific capacity.

Day 1: Run

- Weeks 25-30: build long run 3.5 to 4 miles
- Weeks 31-38: rotate three sessions
 - **Long:** 4 miles easy
 - **Hills:** 8 x 45 sec hard uphill (or 8% treadmill), walk down to recover
 - **Broken 5K:** 1 mile run, 20 burpees, 1 mile run, 20 burpees, 1 mile run. This is the closest simulation of race feel you'll get.

Day 2: Strength

Same as Phase 2, plus:

- **Pull-ups or assisted pull-ups** x max, 3 sets. Bands or a foot on a chair if needed. Even negatives (jump up, lower for 5 sec) count.
- **Sandbag / suitcase carry:** 60 sec, held at chest, walking. Simulates the Hero Carry.
- **Wall get-over drill:** find a waist-high sturdy surface. Hop up, roll over, land. x 10. Hotel version: skip it, do 10 burpee-to-standing-jump instead.

Day 3: Circuit

Same 6 movements, but go 8 rounds, and add a 30 sec dead hang between rounds 4 and 5.

PHASE 4: Terrain and Taper

Weeks 39-47 (Apr 26 - June 26, 2027)

Your 75 acres is the single best training asset you have. Use it.

Weeks 39-45

- **Day 1:** Run on your own property. Off-trail, uneven, tall grass, hills, whatever's soft and awkward. Time-based, 35-45 min. Do not chase pace. If it rained yesterday, that's a

feature.

- **Day 2:** Phase 3 strength, unchanged
- **Day 3:** Circuit outdoors. Real bear crawls, real low crawls in grass, carries with a real object.

Do at least two sessions in the shoes you'll race in, soaking wet. Step in the pond first. Learn how they feel full of water and mud.

Week 46 (June 14-20)

Cut everything to 60%. One easy 25 min run. One light strength session. One easy circuit.

Week 47 (race week)

- Monday: 20 min easy walk or jog
- Wednesday: 15 min easy, a few strides
- Thursday and Friday: rest, hydrate, eat normally
- **Saturday June 26: race**

Gear

Item	Why	Cost
Suspension straps	The only way to train pulling in a hotel room. Hooks over a door. TRX GO is the travel standard at about 1 lb and packs in a carry-on. Budget door-anchor sets under \$50 do the same job for this purpose.	\$40-100
Doorway pull-up bar	For home. Dead hangs are the highest-return exercise in this plan.	\$25-35
Old running shoes	Race day shoes get destroyed. Bog mud at Hugo pulls shoes off feet. Race in old shoes and double-knot them .	\$0
Compression socks or calf sleeves	Not vanity. Protection against brush, barbed wire scrapes, and cold water.	\$15-25

Everything else is optional.

The three rules

1. **Never skip Day 2.** If a week falls apart from travel, the strength day is the one that matters most.
2. **Dead hang every day you can.** 60 seconds is the benchmark. It's the difference between finishing obstacles and walking around them.
3. **Slow is fine.** You're building an 11-month base with zero running background. Injury is the only thing that can actually stop you, and it comes from doing too much too early.

Travel fallback: the 15 minute version

Long flight, bad hotel, no time. Do this and it counts:

- 5 rounds: 10 squats, 10 push-ups, 10 reverse lunges (5 each), 20 mountain climbers, 5 burpees
- 60 sec rest between rounds
- Finish with a dead hang if there's anything to hang from